

ATTACHMENT A - Guidelines for Writing Strengths, Weaknesses and Met Comments

Reviewers should identify and clearly state strengths, weaknesses and/or met comments for each published review criterion. A strength is defined as a response that substantially exceeds requirements set forth in a review criterion. A weakness is defined as a response that falls short of meeting requirements set forth in a review criterion. A met is defined as meeting the baseline requirements of the published criteria. Statements should be constructive and absent of bias and outside information. Please keep in mind that comments will be read by the applicant, and therefore should be appropriate and helpful to the applicant. The following are some guidelines to crafting statements of strengths weaknesses and met.

- Provide a clear and succinct synopsis of the project in the “Overview” in your own words. Do not retype the introduction to the application.
- Use only the published review criteria for all assigned applications. Do not consider factors outside the scope of any review criterion.
- **Make clear, definitive assertions. For example, instead of “The application appears to not have included objectives,” write “The application does not clearly define program objectives.”**
- Use complete declarative sentences (present tense) with language that presents ideas fully. Incomplete sentences and fragments delay the work of producing a cogent and cohesive combined summary statement.
- Depersonalize criticisms. When describing a weakness, always refer to the application’s weaknesses, not the applicant. Reviewers are encouraged to address the subject matter in your strengths, weaknesses or met comments, e.g. Work plan, Logic model, Resolution of Challenges, etc.
- Avoid using phrases like “fails to, lacks, could have, should have, appears,” and other negative statements. **For instance, instead of stating “The bio sketches fail to demonstrate organizational expertise,” write “The bio sketches do not clearly demonstrate the organization’s expertise.” The difference is subtle but significant. Also, include an example to support your statement. For instance, the statement “The bio sketches do not clearly demonstrate the organization’s expertise in the area of business management, construction management oversight and community outreach.”**
- Write in the third person (i.e., “The work plan demonstrates...”) rather than the first or second person, (i.e., “This reviewer feels...” or “In the opinion of this reviewer...”). The final summary statement in the ORC will be the combined consensus of all reviewers. Thus, use page numbers in lieu of lengthy passages of text when examples are too lengthy to include, but specific to the statement.
- When using acronyms, write out the entire name followed by the acronym in parenthesis.
- Remember that each application is to be evaluated on its own merit. The evaluation should reflect a clear, objective, explicit, and justified assessment of the application. The reviewer should write the strengths and weaknesses based on how well the applicant develops the proposed project and the extent to which the project is responsive to the published criteria.

- Avoid comparing one application's content, process, or budget to any other assigned application. Each application should be reviewed independently, and be assessed and analyzed based on the facts presented within the application.
- Avoid scoring an application based on personal experiences, outside knowledge, and personal feelings of the application's feasibility.
- Avoid complex formatting in the document, and use 12 point, Times New Roman Font. Reviewers are asked to use only basic formatting (i.e., bold, italic, underline, bullets, and tabs). Please refrain from using numbered bullets.
- Provide information that helps the applicant understand why a particular statement or recommendation was made.
- Review and be sure that the summary statements are completely accurate concerning the presence or absence of information in the application.
- Do not be prescriptive and avoid using phrases like "it would have been strengthened by..."

Below, please see examples of undesirable and desirable ways of stating Strengths and Weaknesses.

EXAMPLE SUMMARY STATEMENT COMMENTS

Desirable

Strength

The applicant organization thoroughly describes a logical evaluation plan with clearly stated project objectives that are closely tied to measurable performance outcomes/standards and incorporate clear methods of longitudinal data collection, analysis, and reporting for each objective.

The proposed plan for disseminating and implementing HCOP project results to the education and/or health professions community, regionally and/or nationally is provided in tabular format. The plan includes a timetable for collection and analysis of data, presentation venues and projected publication sources which are clearly delineated specific venues, media, timelines, etc.

The illustration of the geographic area map combined with the robust description of the target population, clearly demonstrates a need for funding.

The logic model clearly links all the elements to the identified needs, goals, and objectives of the proposed project.

The costs outlined in the budget are reasonable and directed to supporting key personnel and programming that will meet program objectives.

The application clearly describes the purpose, goals, objectives and activities relative to the project objectives, including roles and tasks for identified partners evidenced by letters of support.

The applicant organization provides a well-defined description of a staffing plan with qualified personnel by training and experience, with capabilities and quality of available facilities and personnel, and a description of the applicant's experience administering federal funds and multiple grant awards.

The proposal provides detailed information on what impact the funding will have on the services rendered to clients and patients.

The applicant organization clearly describes the problems and contributing factors, including a clear need for capacity development funds, gaps in organizational capacity, including limitations in system infrastructure and limitations of HIV primary care services.

Weakness

The Work Plan does not provide sufficient information about the system by which students will be tracked from entry into the proposed HCOP through the end of the proposed project.

The Logic Model does not address obstacles it may need to overcome in order for the proposed program to reach self-sufficiency.

The objectives are not written in a measurable manner and the objectives do not include baseline data.

The Impact assessment does not describe the feasibility and effectiveness of plans for replicability of the residency program.

The staffing plan does not clearly detail how all personnel will be compensated for their effort in the proposed project.

The application does not include a clearly defined plan of dissemination of information or products developed with activities and lessons learned.

The application does not clearly describe how the proposed project activities are replicable.

The application does not provide sufficient data to validate that the costs, as outlined in the budget and required resources sections, are reasonable given the scope of work. The number of patients projected to be served under this program is not adequately justified.

Undesirable

Strength

The budget as presented is reasonable. *(There must be support language justifying this finding.)*

Weakness

The applicant organization and/or application fails to present any statistics/numbers of its own members, of youth development and physical activity program directors with whom it communicates, or of the current reach of its projects and products. It fails to specify amounts of technical assistance, workshop presentation, meetings, conference calls or other collaborative activities

Desirable

Met

The application documents that a partnership will be formed between the network and the organization.

The organizational chart delineates the key personnel that will be involved in the proposed project.

The budget justification aligns with the proposed budget request as stated in the NOFO.

The application includes a needs assessment of the target population.

Undesirable

Met

The application meets the minimum requirement.

The response to the needs section of the NOFO meets the baseline requirements.

The application's response in this criterion meets the minimal requirements and expectations of the program.